

useradd -m slacky

Replace *slacky* with whatever user name you prefer. Logging into the KDE4 desktop made me realise that Slackware has finally bought into the idea of desktop effects—KWin effects work out-of-the-box if your VGA supports 3D. It could also be because Slackware has a strict policy of not customising the defaults offered by upstream software projects and here KDE offers desktop effects by default.

Apart from that, the desktop is plain—with only a panel at the bottom, and no extra icons (nor Folder View) on the desktop. Although Slackware has the Intel Wi-Fi drivers for my wireless Ethernet card, it offers no NetworkManager for seamless wireless access point switching. In fact, you'd need to edit files manually or use command line tools like *ifconfig* and *iwconfig* to set up the network.

For a while, I searched online to find a Slackware NetworkManager package, but unfortunately, none of the third-party Slackware software repos (like linuxpackages.net or slacky.eu) had any software available for version 13 as I write this. Hopefully, things would have changed by the time you install it.

Anyway, the */extras/* section of the DVD has a GTK tool called Wicd, which is a drop-in replacement for NetworkManager. While we're on the subject of GTK tools, they all look ugly due to the absence of the gtk-qt theme engines.

Firing up Wicd gave me a permission-denied error message. The good thing is that the error message also gave a tip on how to fix it. And while we're on the subject of error messages, here're a couple more:

- KMix doesn't load because the user doesn't have rights to the sound device.
- Clicking on an unmounted volume in Dolphin displays error messages.

So, I fired up Konsole to fix things. Adding your user name against the following group names in */etc/group* fixes the aforementioned issues:

- **audio** – this fixes the sound issue.
- **video** – although video worked, I still added my user name here for the heck of it.
- **cdrom** – looked like this solved the CD/DVD mounting issue—though I'm not sure.
- **plugdev** – this was to enable the user to mount other volumes (which probably includes optical discs as well; so maybe adding the user name to the *cdrom* group wasn't required).
- **netdev** – well, this fixed the issue with Wicd permissions.

After saving the file with the changes, and a reboot, Wicd and KMix started as soon as I logged in to KDE, and now I could also mount volumes (hard disk partitions and media devices) using Dolphin. What a relief!

Apps and tools

Finally, coming to productivity and entertainment applications, there're a lot—more than what I needed, at least. And because I went for a full installation, I had more choices for each category of tasks than I'd consider healthy. Anyway, various audio and video file formats worked just fine—even in default KDE apps like JuK and Dragon Player. Yes, there's Amarok and MPlayer (as well as Xine UI) for power users—I missed SMPlayer though. Only thing you'd have to do manually is get the Flash Player from Adobe, Gnash, or elsewhere.

Talk about an office productivity suite and this is where Slackware is a BIG let down. It only offers KOffice version 2, instead of OpenOffice.org 3. I'd like to report here that I never really had issues with the earlier versions of KOffice. But ever since version 2 is out, I find its font rendering capabilities absolutely pathetic—the characters/alphabets look 'fat' with a reddish tinge on black fonts.

Anyway, the good thing is that the accompanying LFY CD has OpenOffice.org 3.1, and you can install it by following this guide: http://wiki.services.openoffice.org/wiki/Documentation/FAQ/Installation/How_do_I_install_OpenOffice.org_on_Slackware%3F

It works like a charm, but the OOo application icons in the menu and run dialogue boxes will be missing. And since UK and US dictionaries don't get installed—you can make use of the OOo Extension Manager (utility located under the *Tools* menu) to find and install them.

Thankfully, the version of Firefox is 3.5, and I also have KTorrent, Kget and other assorted Internet apps that I require. The GIMP is also available; however, Digikam is missing.

Well, that basically completes my requirement factors. If you care about programming languages, server-type software, games et al, updated versions of most are available when you go for the default installation. There's even the XFCE desktop for those who like GTKish stuff—sorry, no GNOME here.

As for bugs, the only one I came across was that sometimes, after logging in, pressing Alt+F2 launched the XFCE run dialogue instead of KRunner. A re-login solved this issue. I have no clue why this happens, but it's pretty annoying.

At the end of the day...

I think Slackware scores because of its stability and a lower dependency on memory compared to the rest of the distros. However, it requires plenty of manual configurations before one can be productive. If you can get along fine with that, I guess you won't have much to worry about. 

By: Atanu Datta

He likes to head bang and play air guitar in his spare time. Oh, and he's also a part of the LFY Bureau.